



Careers and identity in flexible working: Do flexible identities fare better?

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ABSTRACT

The relationship between personal identity and experience of individual career change and flexible working was investigated. Cluster analyses with survey data from 596 employees in 14 companies with varying levels of flexibility indicated the existence of four types of personal identity: the critical-flexible, self-determined, continuous, and job-centred type. The types were explicated further on the basis of narrative interviews with 59 individuals with either a continuous or discontinuous work biography. The types differed significantly in the identity dimensions biographical continuity, ecological consistency, and locus of control as well as in career-related self-esteem and satisfaction with their employment situation, especially their psychological contract. The continuous type expressed the highest and the critical-flexible type the least satisfaction. Consequences for career management and identity research are discussed.

KEYWORDS

career change ■ career management ■ career success ■ personal identity ■ psychological contract ■ work flexibility

Introduction

Over the last few decades, many companies have undergone major changes, aiming to increase flexibility to better handle demands in complex and dynamic economic and societal environments (e.g. Reilly, 1998; Tregaskis et al., 1998). Flexibility in organizations has been defined in terms of

locational, temporal, functional, financial, and numerical flexibility (Reilly, 1998), referring to work being carried out at different locations (e.g. working from home), within open time arrangements (e.g. flexitime), with changing/expanding job descriptions, with variable pay (e.g. pay for performance), and within more open forms of employment (e.g. contract work) respectively. These flexible work arrangements have also affected the employment relationship in a number of ways, for example by increasing the use of contingent labour (e.g. Barley & Kunda, 2004) and causing career paths to cross organizational borders more frequently (e.g. Arthur & Rousseau, 1996). The most fundamental effects probably stem from the challenging of the traditional career or 'standard work biography' (Heinz, 2002) as the societal norm (Sennett, 1998). This standard work biography – standard in as much as it applies to substantial numbers of (male) employees in Western economies – has been defined in terms of continuous employment in the learnt profession, upward mobility within one company and experience of social integration through employment (Beck, 1992; Hall, 2002). While there have always been instances of less linear careers, it is assumed that careers characterized by major occupational reorientations including changes of employers and occupations and phases of unemployment will become prevalent (e.g. Arnold, 1997; Arthur et al., 1999; Kieselbach, 2006).

In career management literature these changes have given rise to concepts such as the boundaryless career (Arthur & Rousseau, 1996) and the protean career (Hall, 2002). Common to these concepts is the assumption that careers involve more self-directed job mobility and a shift in the employment relationship from long-term loyalty and employer-managed careers to a focus on competence development, employability and self-managed careers (e.g. Eby et al., 2003).

Given the strong link between work biography and personal identity in Western societies (Baumeister & Muraven, 1996), the discussion of these emergent forms of careers has always been associated with a debate on successful identity development (e.g. Arthur et al., 1999; Ibarra, 2003; Sennett, 1998). In career research, the concept of identity is usually referred to in a rather general manner, using it synonymously with concepts such as self-concept or sense of self. Identity development is described in similarly general terms, for instance by assuming that individuals who experience different roles also form different subidentities, which change over time as roles and their significance and combinations change (see Arthur & Rousseau, 1996; Hall, 2002). Hall has defined identity development as 'a "metacomptency" that is needed to help the person experience success during the course of the career' (Hall, 2002: 32). Psychological success founded on

a strong sense of self that guides the necessary adaptations in the new independent, self-directed careers is regarded as a crucial indicator for career success (Hall, 2002; Hall & Chandler, 2005; Mirvis & Hall, 1994). However, Hall (2002: 189) also states that knowledge is still lacking on the interaction between a 'protean career identity' and career success and on how people map changes in their objectively more and more boundaryless careers onto their identity.

When turning to identity research in search of a more discriminating framework for studying changes in identity occurring within boundaryless and protean careers, one finds comparatively few studies on adult identity development and even fewer focusing specifically on work biographies. Often these studies are also biased towards the traditional assumption in identity research that biographical stability and continuity are crucial for successful identity development (Erikson, 1968). One interesting exception is a study by Heinz (2002) in which work biographies of almost 1000 adolescents were grouped into six modes of 'biographical agency'. Several types were found that valued continuity highly, but one type emerged that interpreted employment discontinuities as a search for orientation and 'meaningful occupational contexts' (Heinz, 2002: 234) thus constructing a new kind of central theme in their work biography.

Another noteworthy exception is the work by Whitbourne (1986a), who studied antecedents and consequences of 'identity flexibility' which she defined as 'the process of deliberate and informed comparison of one's present identity commitments with other possibilities' (Whitbourne, 1986a: 164). It was found that the personality characteristic openness to experience was related to higher levels of identity flexibility, while age was inversely related to identity flexibility. The only significant predictor for implementing desired life changes, though, was years of education.

This finding is in line with the argument that opportunities for learning and personal development offered through increasing work flexibility (Reilly, 1998) may be beneficial only for individuals who both seek more flexibility and possess a high level of personal resources based on education as well as general socio-economic status (Beck, 1992; Brown et al., 2007). In a recent study of 65 portfolio workers by Totterdell et al. (2006), it was found that the majority preferred their current work situation to permanent employment because of the increased levels of autonomy and flexibility. At the same time, the portfolio workers were generally highly qualified, with 70 per cent of them having been trained for a second occupation, 49 per cent for a third occupation, and 18 per cent for yet a fourth occupation.

Summarizing, there is a general understanding that demands on self-directed independent careers in the context of flexible working pose new

challenges for identity development. Empirical accounts of the specific interactions between personal identity, career change and flexible working are scarce, however, and tend to be based on case studies (e.g. Arthur et al., 1999; Ibarra, 2003). There is still little generalizable knowledge on how people map changes in their increasingly boundaryless careers onto their identity and on how new forms of career identities and career success interact (Hall, 2002).

Our aim was to address this research gap by studying the relationship between personal identity and experience of individual career change and flexible working using a mixed methods approach (Creswell, 2003). We were particularly interested in those parts of personal identity that concern work-related experiences, which have also been termed career identity (Hall, 2002). As in previous career identity research (e.g. Arthur et al., 1999; Ibarra, 2003), we used a qualitative approach to gain a deeper understanding of challenges and opportunities arising from non-traditional forms of work biographies for individuals. Additionally though, we extended the obtained insights beyond individual cases by studying the relevant relationships in a large sample of employees from various companies with different degrees and types of flexible work arrangements.

Specifically, our research had two objectives: 1) to identify identity types among a broad range of individuals who have experienced various degrees of career change and work flexibility; and 2) to compare the obtained types in terms of objective and subjective career success. Despite the considerable body of research on career and identity development, we chose an exploratory approach in pursuing these two objectives. The current state of knowledge allowed neither the prediction of particular identity types nor of specific differences between types, once types could be established.

We based our research on an understanding of identity as a patchwork of self-perceptions collected over time and in different contexts that are used to actively construct biographical continuity on a day-to-day basis (Keupp et al., 1999). In this view, identity serves as a schema through which the individual's experiences are interpreted, structured and integrated in an open-ended, non-normative process (Hausser, 1995; Marcia, 1980; Whitbourne, 1986b). We distinguished between three components of identity: biographical continuity, ecological consistency, and locus of control. These components are frequently discussed in identity research and also seemed particularly relevant for studying relationships between personal identity and experience of individual career change and flexible working (e.g. Erikson, 1968; Hausser, 1995; Marcia, 1980; Raeder & Grote, 2007). Biographical continuity refers to the immediate perception of one's self-sameness and continuity in time. Major changes in individuals' work biography challenge this sense of continuity, potentially leading to disruptions in identity construction and development. Ecological consistency (Hausser, 1995;

Raeder & Grote, 2007) concerns the perception of coherence of one's own behaviour across different spheres of life. As self-directed use of flexible work arrangements may allow for better coordination between different life interests, ecological consistency might increase. Finally, locus of control defined as generalized beliefs about personally relevant events being contingent upon one's own behaviour or on external factors (Hausser, 1995; Rotter, 1966) may be shifted towards more reliance on internal personal resources through the demands and challenges of more independent and self-directed careers (Weick, 1996).

Regarding the first research objective, the identification of identity types, our interest in deriving a typology with respect to expressions of personal identity along these three dimensions was fuelled by two considerations: a) we wanted to describe identity in terms of different components such as continuity or consistency, while at the same time accounting for the holistic nature of identity. A pattern-analytic procedure seemed most appropriate for this purpose; b) the analysis was to be open enough to allow for sensible groupings of individuals not necessarily related to differences in career paths or differences in the degree of flexible working in order to evaluate the presumed importance of both for the development of different forms of personal identities.

In order to pursue the second research objective, that is the comparison of the identity types found with respect to career success, the following four indicators were used:

- 1) Hierarchical level reached in the current employment situation, which is a commonly used indicator of objective career success (Arthur et al., 2005);

- 2) Career-related self-esteem – while general self-esteem may be regarded as a fairly stable personality construct (e.g. Judge et al., 1997), career-related self-esteem is considered to be a more variable personal characteristic influenced by mastering career challenges (Hall, 2002), expressing also successful identity development (e.g. Berzonsky, 2003; Serafini & Adams, 2002; Whitbourne et al., 2002).

Instead of including general job satisfaction, which is a very commonly used indicator of subjective career success (Arthur et al., 2005), we chose two indicators of satisfaction with the work situation that were more specifically geared to our chosen context of flexible working;

- 3) Personal evaluation of experienced work flexibility along the five dimensions of locational, temporal, functional, financial, and numerical flexibility as distinguished by Reilly (1998);

- 4) Assessment of the psychological contract – the psychological contract between employees and their employers consists of unwritten reciprocal obligations and expectations beyond those specified in the legal

work contract (e.g. Kotter, 1973; Rousseau, 1989). Studying individual assessment of the employment relationship through the lens of the psychological contract allows highlighting new requirements accompanying flexible working such as remaining employable through adequate career management and showing higher performance orientation (Anderson & Schalk, 1998; Hall, 2002; Sturges et al., 2003; Yan et al., 2002).

By comparing the different identity types with respect to the chosen indicators of objective and subjective career success, the frequently mentioned assumption could be explored that individuals with more self-directed independent careers should experience flexible working and the corresponding psychological contract with their employer particularly positively (Mirvis & Hall, 1994).

Method

Our study set out to explore the relationship between personal identity and experience of individual career change and flexible working based on a combination of qualitative and quantitative methodologies. The study was conducted with two independent samples, following Sullivan and Arthur's (2006: 27) recommendation to 'go beyond organizational career samples'. With the first sample, which contained both individuals with continuous and discontinuous work biographies, we followed a qualitative biographical approach resulting in rich descriptions of very diverse career histories and their embeddedness in conceptions of personal identity. While previous research on the emergence of new careers has focused on individuals with non-traditional careers only (e.g. Arthur et al., 1999; Ibarra, 2003), our mixed sample permitted exploration of the relevance of traditional and non-traditional work-related experiences in the construction of identities. The second sample contained employees from different companies with varying degrees of flexible work arrangements who responded to a quantitative employee survey. This allowed us to systematically consider flexibility in individual careers as well as in the employing organizations in a larger sample. Data in the two samples were collected in parallel and linked via the search for and explication of identity types, following what has been termed a concurrent transformative strategy (Creswell, 2003). This strategy has the major advantage, which was considered crucial for the present study, that data analysis and interpretation can be carried out recursively, drawing on both the rich qualitative information obtained in one sample and the larger number of cases in the other sample within the same theoretical and analytical framework. This advantage was considered to outweigh the obvious

disadvantage that results obtained from one sample with one set of methods could not inform the second data collection. Another possible disadvantage concerning difficulties in comparing results due to different data formats was addressed by modelling the quantitative measures used in the second sample after the qualitative assessment procedures used in sample 1, which will be described in more detail below.

Participants

Sample 1 comprised 59 individuals living in Switzerland who were selected and contacted on a personal basis. Thirty of these individuals had experienced radical career change (Thomas, 1980) having undergone major voluntary changes in their work biography involving at least one change of profession or occupation. The remaining 29 individuals had rather continuous work biographies possibly with changes in employers and additional training, but had continued to work in the learnt profession or occupation. These two subsamples allowed us to contrast individual experiences in discontinuous versus more traditional continuous careers. Within each sub-sample a mix of educational levels, industrial sectors, and gender was achieved as well as a match between the two sub-samples on these factors. The age of participants was between 40 and 50 ($M = 43.4$, $SD = 3.9$). This age bracket was chosen to allow for sufficient development of work biographies, but also substantial opportunities for future developments. Table 1 provides more details on sample 1.

Table 1 Interview sample of individuals with (dis-)continuous careers (sample 1)

Career type	Career change (<i>n</i> = 30)			Continuous career (<i>n</i> = 29)		
	High school	Technical/ Junior college	University	High school	Technical/ Junior college	University
Highest educational level	8	13	9	6	14	9
Job(s) in agriculture and forestry	—	2	2	—	—	—
Job(s) in industrial sector	6	13	10	4	5	3
Job(s) in service sector	14	30	13	2	9	6
Female	4	6	2	1	7	4
Male	4	7	7	5	7	5

Sample 2 contained 596 employees from 14 companies in Switzerland, which had been chosen on the basis of varying degrees and forms of flexible work arrangements, but which also represented a broad range of industrial sectors and company sizes. The companies were grouped into three degrees of flexibility based on interviews with human resources managers and line managers in each company. Five forms of flexibility were distinguished (Reilly, 1998), namely, locational, temporal, functional, numerical and financial flexibility (see Introduction for definitions of the five forms). Companies were assigned to a high level of flexibility when many forms of flexibility were present and the security of the employment relationship was reduced. A medium level of flexibility entailed many forms of flexibility, but a still comparatively secure employment relationship. A low level of flexibility was assigned when fewer forms of flexibility existed in the company and the security of the employment relationship was not challenged. In smaller companies usually all employees were asked to participate in the survey, while in larger companies departments were selected that were particularly relevant in terms of work flexibility. Table 2 provides more details on sample 2.

Data

Sample 1

In sample 1, semi-structured biographical interviews were carried out containing questions on different phases of the person's work biography, reasons for work-related decisions, personal resources, skill development, and general expectations and evaluations regarding the interviewees' personal situation. From these interviews, descriptions of identity were derived by assigning text units to the three dimensions – biographical continuity, ecological consistency and locus of control – as appropriate. In a follow-up interview, these three dimensions were presented to the interviewees together with the relevant text units. The interviewees were provided with the definitions of the three dimensions and asked to place the text units on a large sheet with the dimensions drawn on it as axes with endpoints described for each dimension (high continuity/low continuity, high consistency/low consistency, internal/external locus of control). This procedure was chosen in accordance with methods suggested for communicative validation of qualitative interview analyses (Groeben & Scheele, 2001). Based on the positioning of the text units along the three identity dimensions, for each dimension an overall qualitative assessment (low, medium, high) was assigned by the researchers.

Table 2 Survey sample in 14 companies with varying degrees of work flexibility (sample 2)

	<i>Companies with high work flexibility (n = 4)</i>	<i>Companies with medium work flexibility (n = 6)</i>	<i>Companies with low work flexibility (n = 4)</i>	<i>Total sample</i>
Type of work flexibility	temporal functional financial numerical locational	temporal functional financial numerical locational	temporal functional financial	
Number of respondents	153	228	215	596
Age				
≤ 30	44	55	21	120
31–40	74	97	67	238
41–50	20	52	65	137
> 50	14	19	57	90
missing	1	5	5	11
Gender				
male	94	118	165	377
female	58	106	48	212
missing	1	4	2	7
Tenure				
< 1 year	22	22	12	56
1–2 years	48	82	26	156
3–5 years	23	36	28	87
5–10 years	27	47	14	88
> 10 years	32	39	133	204
missing	1	2	2	5
Leadership position	66	89	53	208

Career-related self-esteem was operationalized as an evaluation of the self based on the personal reconstruction of work-related experiences captured by the three identity dimensions (Blascovich & Tomaka, 1991; Hall, 2002; Hormuth & Otto, 1996). The interviewees were asked to position the three identity dimensions (biographical continuity, ecological consistency, locus of control) as assessed by themselves along a self-esteem dimension with the endpoints positive versus negative assessment, thereby indicating the degree to which they derived a positive self-evaluation from the pattern of continuity, consistency and locus of control they experienced in their careers. This again was done by physically placing cards with the three identity dimensions on them along an axis on a sheet of paper

representing the self-esteem dimension. An overall assessment for career-related self-esteem was then assigned as for the identity dimensions.

Sample 2

In sample 2, the employee survey contained items covering the three identity dimensions (biographical continuity, ecological consistency, locus of control), assessment of career-related self-esteem, personal evaluations of work flexibility in the company following Reilly's (1998) flexibility dimensions, the perceived psychological contract with the employing organization, and socio-demographic information including career changes and hierarchical position in the company. The questionnaire was specially designed for the study, as there were no appropriate existing measures. Specifically, the identity dimensions biographical continuity and ecological consistency were measured quantitatively, not qualitatively as in most identity research; career-related self-esteem was measured in accordance with the procedure used in sample 1 as an evaluation of the self based on personal reconstructions of work-related experiences captured by the three identity dimensions; in line with previous qualitative identity research, locus of control was operationalized not only in terms of internal versus external orientation, but also included an interactionistic orientation (Hausser, 1995; Hoff et al., 1991); the psychological contract was assessed in terms of elements of traditional versus new employment relationships (Hiltrop, 1995; Raeder & Grote, 2001). More detail on the different measures used is provided below.

Identity dimensions. For sample 2, the survey questions concerning personal identity were designed to mirror the assessment procedures used in sample 1. The identity dimension biographical continuity was measured by the question 'Do you perceive a central theme in your work biography?' Responses were provided on a three-point scale (1 = agree, 2 = partly agree, 3 = disagree). Respondents were also asked to name central themes in their biographies to ensure a more in-depth reflection of their personal situation when answering the question. A list of themes was provided plus space to name additional themes. The identity dimension ecological consistency was measured by the question 'Do you perceive inconsistencies between different spheres of life (work, family, sports etc.)?' Again, responses were provided on a three-point scale (1 = agree, 2 = partly agree, 3 = disagree) and respondents were asked to name reasons for inconsistencies between different parts of their lives. Locus of control was measured by having participants indicate which factors had had an influence on their career decisions (i.e. vocational choice, job change, further training, second education, career change). The factors comprised dimensions of control as used in other questionnaires

(Levenson, 1974): oneself, job situation, people from work, private situation, people from private life, and chance. Respondents were assigned to either internal control (= 1) or external control (= 3), when all their responses expressed an internal or external focus respectively. All other respondents were assigned to interactionist control (i.e. internal and external factors acting together; = 2).

Career-related self-esteem. The participants were asked to assess their own sense of self-worth in light of their statements concerning biographical continuity, ecological consistency and locus of control ('How do you regard yourself overall in light of your assessments of continuity, consistency and control in your work biography?'). Responses were provided on a three-point scale (1 = positively, 2 = neutral, 3 = negatively).

The choice of three-point scales for measuring the identity dimensions and self-esteem was based on the following considerations. The survey questions were modelled after the qualitative interviews by instructing the respondents to reflect on their work biographies and derive global assessments from that. No quantification of intensity was intended by the measurement scales, but rather a qualitative judgement of direction. Prior research indicates that three-point scales are a viable option for this purpose (Matell & Jacoby, 1971, 1972).

Work flexibility. The respondents' subjective views on how the different forms of flexibility had been implemented in their companies were measured by subscales corresponding to the five forms of flexibility (i.e. numerical, functional, financial, locational, and temporal flexibility; see Reilly, 1998). The subscales contained between two and seven items and responses were provided on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 'strongly disagree' to 'strongly agree'. Sample items are as follows: 'I received sufficient information during the outsourcing process' (numerical flexibility); 'I have the opportunity to acquire skills by job rotation, project work or internal changes' (functional flexibility); 'The payment with fixed and variable parts meets my needs' (financial flexibility); 'The company provides satisfactory measures for supporting communication with colleagues working at different locations' (locational flexibility). 'My personal needs were taken into consideration when the flexible time system was implemented' (temporal flexibility). Cronbach's alphas for the subscales were 0.75 (numerical flexibility), 0.71 (functional flexibility), 0.73 (financial flexibility), 0.63 (locational flexibility), and 0.80 (temporal flexibility). The respondents' evaluations of the different forms of flexibility were combined into an overall assessment of flexibility by first calculating a mean for the items pertaining to each of the forms of flexibility and then taking an overall mean across the different forms of flexibility. Respondents were only asked to evaluate those

forms of flexibility that were actually implemented in their companies. Thus, the overall evaluations were not always based on the means for all five subscales.

Psychological contract. The psychological contract items comprised the person's own expectations of and contributions to their employer as well as the person's perceptions of what the company expected and delivered in return with respect to a list of 10 contents each. These contents were derived from existing literature contrasting traditional and new psychological contracts (Anderson & Schalk, 1998; Cavanaugh & Noe, 1999; Herriot & Pemberton, 1995; Hiltrop, 1995; Millward & Brewerton, 2000; Raeder & Grote, 2001) and covered issues such as job security, skill development, loyalty, and career opportunities. Responses were given on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 'strongly disagree' to 'strongly agree'. Difference scores were computed for the corresponding items on expectations and contributions for each content, thereby indicating the degree to which particular expectations had been met. These difference scores were then subjected to a principal components factor analysis with varimax rotation, resulting in six factors which were named Security, Learning opportunities, Career advancement, Focus on achievement goals, Employee flexibility, and Broad skill spectrum. Cronbach's alphas for the scales were 0.71, 0.66, 0.74, 0.54, 0.56 and 0.49 respectively. Due to the low consistencies for the scales on focus on achievement goals and broad skill spectrum, these scales were not used further in the analysis. The low consistency of the scale Employee flexibility was considered acceptable, however, because this scale contained expectations/contributions with rather diverse contents such as geographical mobility and flexible working hours, which are conceptually linked, but for which one would not necessarily expect similar responses.

Socio-demographic information. Participants provided information on career change ('When joining your current company, did you come from a different professional background?': yes/no; 'Which occupation/profession were you in before?'; 'Which occupation/profession are you in now?'), on their hierarchical position (leadership position: yes/no), on their age and their gender. In order to assure anonymity, age was measured in four categories (30 years or younger, 31 to 40 years, 41 to 50 years, more than 50 years).

Results

To accomplish the first research objective, the identification of identity types, cluster analyses were carried out with the sample 2 data. The qualitative case descriptions and quantitative profiles on the three identity dimensions

abstracted from the interview data in sample 1 were then consulted to explicate and illustrate the identity types found in sample 2.

For the cluster analysis, the k-means cluster method was used because it allows pre-specifying and testing cluster solutions with different numbers of clusters and it is very efficient for larger samples (see Bacher, 2002). Solutions for three, four, and five clusters were calculated from the data concerning the three identity dimensions (biographical continuity, ecological consistency, locus of control). The four-cluster solution was chosen as the one with the clearest profile for each cluster and a very high classification adequacy of 98.8 per cent in the discriminant analysis. The ANOVA carried out as part of the k-means analysis confirmed that the four types differed significantly on the three identity dimensions (biographical continuity $F(3, 592) = 400.18, p < .001$; ecological consistency $F(3, 592) = 312.09, p < .001$; locus of control $F(3, 592) = 44.21, p < .001$).

The types were labelled as the 'critical-flexible', 'self-determined', 'continuous', and 'job-centred' types based on their specific value patterns across the three identity dimensions (see Table 3). The four types will be described on the basis of the quantitative profiles obtained in the cluster analysis in sample 2. Qualitative illustrations of the different identity patterns will be provided by referring to interview data from sample 1.

The critical-flexible type (cluster 1) was characterized by medium biographical continuity, medium ecological consistency and an interactionistic locus of control. The label for this cluster was not derived from a particularly distinctive characteristic on the three identity dimensions, but from the profile on the variables used to further discriminate the identity types. The critical-flexible type contained the most job changers and the

Table 3 Cluster centres and results of ANOVAs for clusters in sample 2

	Identity type				ANOVA <i>F</i>
	Critical-flexible	Self-determined	Continuous	Job-centred	
Cluster number	1	2	3	4	
Biographical continuity (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	2.08/.27	2.70/.46	1.24/.43	1.07/.26	400.18***
Ecological consistency (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	1.68/.47	2.69/.47	2.65/.48	1.20/.40	312.09***
Locus of control (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	2.05/.26	1.49/.50	1.94/.37	1.62/.51	44.21***
<i>N</i>	114	71	324	87	

Note: *** $p \leq .001$; *M* = mean, *SD* = standard deviation.

respondents belonging to this type expressed the lowest satisfaction with several aspects of their work situation. This will be described in more detail later. In the qualitative data of sample 1, it could be seen that medium biographical continuity was often expressed by individuals who felt that elements of change and discontinuity were part of an overall fairly continuous process. A person who had changed career several times explained that he tried to integrate skills learnt in former professions into his current work task, but also indicated that his values shifted from a social to an economic orientation. Medium ecological consistency was experienced due to perceived links between work, family and leisure time. A goldsmith mentioned, for instance, that the circles of her private friends and her colleagues from work largely overlapped. An interactionist locus of control was based on the assumption that biographical events are influenced by oneself as well as by the situation. One interviewee described this as 'I can't tell whether the link to my past happened by accident or whether I was consciously looking for it. Possibly, a bit of both.'

The self-determined type (cluster 2) was characterized by low biographical continuity, high ecological consistency, and a comparatively stronger internal locus of control, from which also the label for this type was derived. In the interviews in sample 1, low biographical continuity was connected, for instance, to changes in vocational interests and goals. A woman reported that her parents did not appreciate girls' achievements at school and that therefore her education was considered unimportant. As a consequence, she made no efforts to learn. Only years afterwards she decided to improve her basic knowledge and to show that she is able to learn and to succeed. The experience of a high ecological consistency was often described by the interviewees in terms of their attempts to actively integrate their different spheres of life, for instance by working part-time while the children were young, or from the fact that work was judged as important for developing one's own personality. Also the importance of life beyond work was emphasized, for example, by working as a flying instructor or building a house in southern France in addition to carrying on with their paid work. The individuals in sample 1 who expressed an internal locus of control attributed control to themselves through active and independent decisions on biographical events and attached only subordinate importance to situational factors. An interviewee described the decisions concerning his education, positions in three company divisions and participation in an executive MBA programme as actively chosen, even though he also admitted: 'You are a part somewhere in a process.'

The continuous type (cluster 3) was characterized by high biographical continuity, high ecological consistency, and an interactionist locus of

control. The label for this type was chosen due to the high biographical continuity – which is also a characteristic of the fourth cluster, though – in combination with the high consistency, which provides an overall picture of a very continuous life across time and across different spheres of life. In the interview data from sample 1, it was interesting to see that high biographical continuity was experienced not only by individuals with a continuous career in their profession but also by some individuals who had changed professions. In the latter case, continuity was actively constructed by means of abstract explanations. A career changer generalized for his biography: ‘With every step I took, I added something to what I am today and what I do today.’ Another interviewee reported on his growing responsibility in international projects and commented on his changes of jobs and professions as episodes of disorientation: ‘It was always the same, I didn’t know what to do.’ Disorientation thus served as a central theme aligning his occupational and job changes on a more abstract level. Examples for high ecological consistency and an interactionistic control from the interview data were already provided in the descriptions of previous types.

The job-centred type (cluster 4) had high biographical continuity, the lowest value on ecological consistency, and an interactionist locus of control. Because reasons provided for inconsistency in the questionnaire were usually stemming from a dominance of work over other spheres of life, such as family and leisure activities, this type was called job-centred. In the interview data, low ecological consistency was experienced by a clear separation between work and private life. One interviewee commented regarding his job as police chief that he managed very well to separate private and business. Examples for high biographical continuity and an interactionistic control were already provided in the descriptions of previous types.

In order to address the second research objective, namely to compare the identity types with respect to career success, we performed a MANOVA and Chi-square tests using Bonferroni multiple comparison tests and Bonferroni-Holm alpha adjustment to specify differences between single identity types (see Table 4). Specifically, the identity types were compared with respect to career-related self-esteem, assessment of work flexibility and psychological contract, and leadership position. Also, the proportions of job changers and of respondents from companies with different degrees of work flexibility were compared. Finally, differences in age and gender were checked.

The MANOVA performed to compare the identity types regarding career-related self-esteem, assessment of work flexibility and psychological contract showed an overall significant result (Pillai’s trace = .969 with $F(6, 532) = 2808.25, p < .001$). Respondents in the critical-flexible type

Table 4 Comparison of career success indicators and socio-demographic characteristics for clusters of sample 2

	Identity type						
	Critical-flexible	Self-determined	Continuous	Job-centred			
Cluster number <i>n</i>	1 114	2 71	3 324	4 87			
Leadership position	35 79	9 61	127 190	37 48	χ^2 22.10**	significant differences ^a 2 vs 1, 3, 4	
Job change	51 63	27 44	98 226	26 61	13.08*	1, 2 vs 3, 4	
Work flexibility in company	48 52	31 25	107 111	29 40	23.43**	1 vs 3	
	high medium						
	low	15	106	18			
Age	≤ 30 31–40 41–50 >50	18 20 22 10	64 132 73 52	22 35 14 12	11.75		
Gender	female male	29 40	114 209	26 60	2.76		
					MANOVA <i>F</i>	significant differences ^b	
Career-related self-esteem (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	1.53/.54	1.34/.48	1.22/.43	1.36/.58	10.96**	3 < 1	
Assessment of work flexibility (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	3.11/.76	3.33/.74	3.55/.73	3.23/.71	11.35**	1, 4 < 3	
PC security (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	-.99/.88	-.72/.89	-.49/.69	-.97/.103	13.90**	1, 4 < 3	
PC learning opportunities (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	-.60/.79	-.52/.84	-.45/.68	-.78/.87	4.56*	4 < 3	
PC career advancement (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	-1.02/1.10	-.78/.98	-.64/.91	-1.08/1.12	6.39**	1, 4 < 3	
PC employee flexibility (<i>M</i> / <i>SD</i>)	-.28/.75	-.09/.71	-.00/.78	-.20/.73	3.97*	1 < 3	

Note. * $p \leq .01$; ** $p \leq .001$; *M* = mean, *SD* = standard deviation, PC = psychological contract.

^a The error rate in familywise χ^2 tests was adjusted by the Bonferroni-Holm procedure.

^b Multiple comparisons were computed with Bonferroni multiple comparison tests.

expressed the lowest self-esteem and the continuous type the highest self-esteem ($F(3, 537) = 10.96, p < .001$). The continuous type assessed work flexibility more positively than all other types ($F(3, 537) = 11.35, p < .001$). In the evaluation of the psychological contract, there was generally a gap reported between what the company delivered and what respondents expected, but this gap was most pronounced for the critical-flexible and job-centred types. There were statistically significant differences for the corresponding three factors of the psychological contract, that is, Security ($F(3, 537) = 13.90, p < .001$), Learning opportunities ($F(3, 537) = 4.56, p < .01$), and Career advancement ($F(3, 537) = 6.39, p < .001$). Individuals' contributions and firms' expectations regarding employee flexibility were generally seen as more compatible. The most negative values were found for the critical-flexible type ($F(3, 537) = 3.97, p < .01$).

In the continuous and job-centred types, a fairly high percentage of respondents in leadership positions was found (40% and 44% respectively), while in the critical-flexible type and especially the self-determined type, there were substantially fewer managers (31% and 13% respectively) (Chi-square (3, $N = 586$) = 22.10, $p < .001$). The largest proportion of career changers was found in both the critical-flexible and the self-determined type (45% and 38% respectively), while people with continuous careers were found proportionally more in the continuous and job-centred type (72% and 73% respectively) (Chi-square (3, $N = 582$) = 13.08, $p < .01$). Regarding the degree of flexibility in the employing company, the most substantial difference was found between the continuous and the critical-flexible type (Chi-square (6, $N = 596$) = 23.43, $p < .001$). Respondents belonging to the continuous type were equally distributed across companies with different degrees of flexibility, while respondents belonging to the critical-flexible type were found mostly in companies with medium or high flexibility.

Finally, there were no statistically significant differences between the types with respect to the socio-demographic variables of age and gender.

Discussion

Identity types

The main result related to our first research objective, the identification of identity types, was that four types of identity, namely the critical-flexible, self-determined, continuous, and job-centred type, could indeed be singled out. All types had different patterns on the three identity dimensions biographical continuity, ecological consistency, and locus of control. They also had different profiles regarding career success as indicated by career-related self-esteem,

assessment of work flexibility and psychological contract, and leadership position. Finally, the types differed with respect to proportions of job changers and of respondents from companies with different degrees of work flexibility. While the types were derived from cluster analyses with the survey data from sample 2, the identity types were also exemplified by means of the qualitative data from the biographical interviews in sample 1. This represents an important strength of the chosen concurrent transformative strategy for the study design (Creswell, 2003).

To our knowledge, there is no similarly constructed typology to which the types found could be compared. Nevertheless, there is some correspondence between the types and the modes of biographical agency reported by Heinz (2002). For example the mode of advancement ambition would probably be found to be very relevant to individuals belonging to the continuous and job-centred types, while the mode of personal growth most likely would be predominant in the self-determined type.

There were no gender differences evident to support the supposition that women exhibit less traditional career patterns and are better equipped to handle flexibility. This conforms with other studies which also found no gender differences in career preferences (Briscoe et al., 2006) or even reverse differences as women followed traditional careers more often (Reitmann & Schneer, 2003).

Career success

Regarding the second research objective, that is the comparison of the identity types on a number of characteristics concerning career success, two results stand out. Individuals in the continuous type expressed the most positive assessment of their employment relationship and also tended to have greater career progression, with 40 per cent being in leadership positions. Only the job-centred type contained relatively more individuals in leadership positions, these assessed their employment situation rather negatively, however. This might be some variant of the career success/personal failure combination described by Korman and Korman (1980), as the job-centred type was also characterized by rather low ecological consistency.

Second, the individuals in the critical-flexible type not only perceived their employment situation rather negatively, but also expressed the lowest self-esteem. This might indicate a potential instability in the identity construction of the critical-flexible type in support of the view dominant in identity research that biographical continuity is an essential ingredient for a sound identity (Erikson, 1968; Kroger, 2000; Marcia, 1980). At the same time, the interview data did show that even individuals with very discontinuous careers

– as was also characteristic of the critical-flexible type – constructed their identities quite successfully. They positively acknowledged elements of both continuity and discontinuity in their lives and expressed high self-esteem. This finding is in line with Keupp et al.'s (1999) proposal to comprehend identity as a patchwork composed of self-perceptions collected over time and in different contexts that are used to actively construct biographical continuity on a day-to-day basis. Such a process possibly consists of different stages characterized by more or less continuity, captured for instance in the different types of identity status – identity diffusion, moratorium, foreclosure, and identity achievement – suggested by Marcia (1980), which an individual can experience repeatedly during his or her life-course.

Prevalence of traditional careers

Given the positive findings regarding career success for the continuous type and considering also the fact that the continuous type was the by far most frequent type, one might question the necessity for individual flexibility proclaimed by practitioners and researchers alike (e.g. Fugate et al., 2004; Ostroff & Clark, 2001). From the data of our study, it appears that people in more continuous careers felt most supported in their personal learning and career advancement. They were also more satisfied with the degree of job security that was offered to them. This is not so surprising because compared to the other types they were more often employed by companies with lower degrees of flexibility in which psychological contracts were still built on stability and loyalty. At the same time, no less than two-thirds of the individuals belonging to the continuous type worked in organizations with medium or high flexibility. One may assume that they were doing well even in these organizations because the success experienced in their careers has helped to build personal resources useful for coping with flexibility demands also.

Contrary to commonly held views on the benefits of self-directed and independent careers, those persons who actively seek flexible careers and show more fluid forms of personal identity as captured by the critical-flexible type, seem not to benefit from work flexibility. This finding mirrors the doubts voiced by Arthur et al. (2005) concerning companies' readiness to support the self-directed career actor. Astonishingly, the critical-flexible type even displays the largest negative discrepancy between flexibility offered by the employees and flexibility perceived as demanded by the company. In interpreting this result, it has to be kept in mind that the critical-flexible type tended to work in companies with fairly high flexibility demands. It appears that the process of (self-)selection based on individual and organizational

flexibility demands does not lead to a good fit between person and organization. This might be due to the companies changing in unexpected ways in the course of employment, which would seem to be particularly likely for very flexible companies. Another possibility is that flexibility demands perceived by employees in the critical-flexible type do not exceed the flexibility they are willing to offer as such, but rather there might be a mismatch between the kinds of flexibility demanded and offered (see Yan et al., 2002, for a similar line of thought regarding international assignments). For instance, these highly flexible individuals might well be willing to train for a new job, but they might not be willing to work more flexible hours, given their sense of work-life balance expressed in a medium to high ecological consistency.

Self-determined type as avant-garde

The most interesting type with respect to handling flexibility demands appears to be the self-determined type, as many individuals in this type worked in the most flexible companies and at the same time evaluated the offer of job security more positively than both the job-centred and the critical-flexible type. However, there were very few people holding leadership positions in this type, indicating less traditionally successful careers (Arthur et al., 2005). This result could not be attributed to age, as there were no significant age differences between the types. The self-determined type might be exemplary for Hall's argument that with more independent and self-directed careers, psychological success becomes more important than objective career success (Hall & Chandler, 2005; Hall & Mirvis, 1995).

Additionally, respondents belonging to the self-determined type more often expressed an internal locus of control. Based on the research by Hoff et al. (1991), one would assume an internal locus of control to be inferior to an interactionist locus of control, which in their study of the personality development of skilled workers appeared to be the most advanced stage of development. Given that their study was conducted in the 1980s in Germany, which was a period of high unemployment with more traditional and less flexible employment relationships, it would be very interesting to follow up on their research now. It is conceivable that an internal locus of control gains in importance in highly flexible environments in order to keep the individual focused and to help structure these 'weak situations' (Weick, 1996: 43f.).

Finally, the self-determined type is interesting as the least frequent type in both samples. Individuals belonging to this type tended to work in the most flexible work arrangements, which are not yet widespread. If one

considers highly flexible work arrangements as the employment of the future (e.g. Arthur & Rousseau, 1996; Barley & Kunda, 2004; Voss & Pongratz, 1998; Willke, 1999), the self-determined type might be the one to model measures for education, career development and human resource management after.

Study limitations

The most important limitations of the present study are restrictions on measurement equivalence for qualitative and quantitative accounts of the same constructs, limited knowledge about the specific contexts within which the respondents worked in their companies, the cross-sectional design, and reduced generalizability due to sample selection.

The chosen concurrent mixed methods design allowed identification of the identity types in a large survey sample and to explicate and illustrate the types further by means of qualitative data gathered from biographical interviews. In order to further validate the four identity types, a large and diverse sample of employees should be surveyed based on improved operationalizations of the key constructs, for which the current study provides a very good basis. Also, the assumed mismatches between offered and demanded flexibility in the employment relationship should be analysed further in concrete work settings. This could provide more substantial evidence for the proposition that despite all calls for employee flexibility, it is still the employees with comparatively continuous careers that are furthered most in their development through their employers. In addition, the inclusion of more measures of work and life success and psychosocial well-being would be useful to support the claim that successful identity development can be achieved in highly discontinuous biographies. A longitudinal study of identity development would be particularly beneficial, which would allow testing predictions of success or failure in handling different employment situations, given a particular identity type. Thereby, also claims on cause and effect relationships among biography, identity type, work flexibility and assessment of the employment relationship could be substantiated.

Even though individuals with very diverse educational backgrounds and employment situations were included in the samples studied, overall only comparatively successful and resourceful individuals with still fairly traditional employment relationships took part in the investigation. As already found by Whitbourne (1986a), our study may have provided evidence for successful development of flexible identities based on high levels of personal resources only. A broader sample including individuals who work

in more complex employment situations (e.g. portfolio work), have lost their jobs, work in jobs well beneath their qualification level, and/or have very little formal education would be required to test the generalizability of the identity types and to increase our understanding of preconditions for more flexible and less continuity-oriented personal identities.

Concluding remarks

An important challenge for future research will be to better capture the dynamics of work biographies within the framework of the suggested identity types. Using biographical information in constructing the typology implies that individuals, despite developing their personal identity, continuously belong to the same type. It might well be, though, that the types – similar to the forms of identity status suggested by Marcia (1980) – can also represent different phases in the course of a person's life, with one particular type chosen as the most fitting to a person's life-long identity development only in hindsight. The types suggested here differ from Marcia's concept of identity status, though, because in his model the status identity achievement is considered the status to be reached sooner or later in order for a person to develop a sound identity. No such assumption is made with respect to any of the types identified in our study. However, it would be very important to investigate whether there are more or less successful development paths involving changes between the types.

In a more practical vein, our research points to some consequences for human resource management, specifically for career management. Flexible working and insecure work situations are often discussed as being an inevitable result of current economic developments. As an important contribution to individual well-being as much as to long-term company performance, human resource management should support the experience of fairness within the employment relationship even under conditions of highly flexible employment relationships (e.g. Pfeffer, 1998). Our study indicates on the one hand that there are individuals who have developed a sound personal identity based on more discontinuous and flexible work arrangements, but that on the other hand individuals with more traditional continuity-based orientations may succeed more in their careers even in flexible work organizations.

It appears that demands for flexibility need to be defined much more clearly in order not to mislead employees. If despite all calls for taking on responsibility for one's own employability, it is the employees with traditional careers within one profession that are supported most, many

employees who have invested in further education, potentially even changing their professions, will be left frustrated and demotivated – if not jobless. Employability demands have to be specified and employees helped by systematic personnel development measures to develop the skills needed to handle the flexibility required of them. The overall objective has to be a fair distribution of employment risks between employer and employee, taking into consideration each employee's personal resources for coping with these risks. The identity types found in the present study may provide a good basis for making the necessary judgements.

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